

InfraPandit AWARDS 2025

It was the culmination of a long-held dream when The Infravision Foundation joined hands with the construction behemoth L&T to recognise industry-academia collaboration by awarding two InfraPandit awards for breakthrough solutions in access to solar energy and urban sanitation. It was an evening of recognising the importance of research in infrastructure development and its readiness for real world implementation.

Editor's Note

For an infrastructure related project, the turnaround was quick. The Infravision Foundation (TIF) announced the InfraPandit Awards for excellence in doctoral research in infrastructure in July. By mid-October, TIF had received 27 applications from 16 prestigious institutions, and had shortlisted ten of them for the jury to vet. With that done, November 29 was the big day when the InfraPandit Awards were formally announced. Here's to greater collaboration between industry and academia.



The lighting of the lamp marks an auspicious beginning. Seen here are TIF Co founder and Managing Trustee Rumjhum Chatterjee, InfraPandit Awards Jury chair Prof. G. Raghuram, TIF Founder and Managing Trustee Vinayak Chatterjee, InfraPandit Awards Jury member Savita Mahajan, and L&T Senior Vice President & Head- Buildings and Factories Sthaladipti Saha.



InfraPandit Uttam Award (first prize) winner Dr Shubham Jain with the Chief Guest and the founders of TIF



InfraPandit Mahaan Award (second prize) winner Dr Paresh Chhajed with the Chief Guest and the founders of TIF

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Celebrating the Next Generation of Infra Research

The InfraPandit Awards 2025 recognised two doctoral research contributions addressing India's pressing infrastructure priorities: clean energy access and urban sanitation, both central to the nation's path towards sustainability and resilience.

This inaugural edition was held on November 29, 2025, at the India Habitat Centre, New Delhi, and graced by chief guest Sthaladipti Saha, Senior Vice President & Head - Buildings & Factories, L&T Construction. "If infrastructure is the language in which the nation expresses its ambition, science is its grammar." The next leap, he said, would not only be through scale but also digitisation, sustainability and climate resilience. L&T, he said, also stood for learning and training. "That's why doctoral research is essential to this journey. India's future is not only in concrete and steel but also in its intellect, insight and imagination," he added.

The InfraPandit Awards received strong national interest, with applications from 16 prestigious institutions across India, including IIT Kanpur, SPA New Delhi, BITS Pilani, IIT Roorkee, IIM Ahmedabad, IISc Bengaluru, Jadavpur University, IIT Delhi, IIT Bombay, MNIT Jaipur, Panjab University, NIT Calicut, NIT Warangal, IIT Jammu, RICS-Amity, and JNU.

Notably, 33 per cent of the applicants were women, reflecting a growing gender balance and increasing female leadership in India's infrastructure research ecosystem. The submissions also showcased the depth and diversity of India's emerging research landscape, with proposals spanning technology and innovation; agriculture, land, and food systems; social sciences and human development; energy and environment; urban transport infrastructure and governance; and civil and infrastructure engineering.

The InfraPandit Awards, instituted by The Infravision Foundation in collaboration with Larsen & Toubro, celebrate outstanding PhD work that bridges academic excellence with practical relevance, addressing complex infrastructure challenges across engineering, technology, management, finance, and policy. These awards seek to nurture emerging leaders who will significantly contribute to India's vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047, strengthening the long-term industry-academia interface. The Infravision Foundation will continue engaging with the awardees through publication support, policy dialogues, applied research partnerships, and wider dissemination of their work, reinforcing its commitment to advancing evidence-based solutions for India's infrastructure future.

This year's ceremony marked a pivotal step forward in encouraging solution-oriented doctoral research vital for India's infrastructure transition, with the InfraPandit Awards serving as a beacon fostering innovation, collaboration, and knowledge dissemination



Left to Right: Jagan Shah, CEO, TIF; Prof. G. Raghuram, Former Director, IIM-Bangalore and Former Dean, IIM Ahmedabad, Jury Chair, InfraPandit Awards; Sthaladipti Saha, Senior Vice President & Head- Buildings and Factories at Larsen & Toubro; Dr. Pareesh Jawarilal Chhajed, InfraPandit Mahaan Award winner (2nd prize); Dr. Shubham Jain, InfraPandit Uttam Award Winner (1st prize); Savita Mahajan, Advisor and Independent Director, Jury Member (InfraPandit Awards); Rumjhum Chatterjee, Co-Founder and Managing Trustee at The Infravision Foundation; Vinayak Chatterjee, Founder and Trustee, The Infravision Foundation

The Winners

The prestigious Uttam Award, carrying a cash prize of ₹5 lakh, was bestowed upon Dr. Shubham Jain, who completed his PhD from the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi. His research focuses on developing a versatile cascade latent heat storage system for solar cooking applications, including the creation of a patented solar-powered thermal battery capable of multi-temperature indoor cooking. This breakthrough offers a practical, affordable, and scalable clean-energy solution at a time when India is rapidly advancing towards low-carbon domestic and industrial systems. His work addresses critical national challenges—household air pollution, unreliable access to clean energy, and the need for sustainable thermal solutions in industrial processes, aligning strongly with India's clean technology roadmap and long-term climate commitments. A large-scale deployment of the technology is already planned in Ladakh, where it will support solar cooking, drying, and community-level space heating.

The Mahaan Award, accompanied by a cash prize of ₹3 lakh, was presented to Dr. Paresh Jawarilal Chhajed, who earned his PhD from the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay for his seminal work on scaling Faecal Sludge Management (FSM) in India's small cities, providing a governance and policy framework for non-conventional sanitation systems where conventional sewerage remains financially and spatially unviable. His work addresses a critical gap in urban infrastructure and public health, supporting the broader national priorities of Swachh Bharat, AMRUT, and sustainable urbanisation. His research includes a systematic analysis of sanitation systems across more than 60 cities supported by comparative case studies, uncovering service bottlenecks and highlighting the interplay between technology, institutions, and governance. His findings have already informed practice, including his invitation to contribute to the Integrated Wastewater and Septage Management Guidelines for the State of Kerala under the Sustainable Urban Development – Smart Cities Project.

Following the completion of their PhDs earlier this year, both winners continue to actively contribute to applied research. Dr. Jain is currently a Research Associate at the Ashoka Centre for a People-Centric Energy Transition (ACPET), New Delhi, where his work focuses on clean technology innovation, industrial decarbonisation, and sustainable energy systems. Dr. Chhajed currently serves as a Project Manager at the Ashank Desai Centre for Policy Studies at IIT Bombay, where he is engaged in a short research project building on governance, policy design, and implementation frameworks for infrastructure systems.

The awardees were selected through a rigorous two-stage evaluation process led by a distinguished jury comprising: Prof. G Raghuram, Chairman of the Jury and former Director of IIM Bangalore; Ms. Savita Mahajan, a senior management professional with a key role in setting up the Mohali campus of the Indian School of Business, as well as decades of leadership in industry and education; Dr. K.P. Krishnan, a retired IAS officer with extensive government and international experience; Dr. Soumya Kanti Ghosh, Group Chief Economic Advisor at State Bank of India and Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council member; and Dr. Janmejaya Sinha, Chairman of Boston Consulting Group India.



Sthaladipti Saha delivering his keynote address



Dr Shubham Jain



Dr Paresh Chhajed

TIF CEO Spreads the Infra Word

TIF CEO Jagan Shah was on overdrive in November, speaking at events, participating in workshops and offering suggestions at key stakeholder meetings. On November 3, Shah was at a workshop on NITI Aayog's new initiative called the Hill City Regions Planning Initiative (HCRPI) in Shillong, Meghalaya, through which NITI Aayog will develop a strategy for developing resilient and culturally rooted growth centres in the hilly states of Himalayan Region in particular. TIF presented international case studies and participated in the deliberations, underlining the importance of unified thinking on hilly cities and their peculiar transportation and mobility challenges, an issue that resonated with the workshop participants from hilly cities.



Jagan Shah at Hill Cities event

Shah participated in a discussion organised by Urban Land Institute (ULI) India on November 11, where Anna Roy, Special Adviser, NITI Aayog, delivered a lecture on economic growth hubs. It was followed by a discussion on cities as growth hubs. Shah was asked to speak about the importance of transportation infrastructure to urban development and the institutional arrangements required to make it serve the national purpose of economic growth.



Jagan Shah at ULI conference

The week of November 17 was particularly hectic. It saw the CEO as Juror at the Urban Planning Department at CEPT University on November 18, then on November 20, he participated in a panel titled "Is urban land affordable" organised by RICS Institute in the India Land and Development Conference at the Ahmedabad Management Association. On November 21, he presented TIF's recommendations before the finance minister in a Pre-Budget meeting organised by the Ministry of Finance with infrastructure and energy sector stakeholders. That same afternoon, he participated in a session on 'Antyodaya to Sarvodaya: Shaping India's Small Towns for Everyone' in the BUILD INDIA VISION event organised by the Festival of Architecture & Interior Designing (FOAID) and TV18.



Jagan Shah at pre-budget consultation with Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

On November 25, Shah participated as a Juror for The Namma Bengaluru Challenge to shortlist ten recipients who will receive Rs 25 lakh each to testbed their solutions in Bengaluru during 2026. The Challenge is a collaboration between UnboxingBLR, Social Alpha and WTFund, and is supported by the Government of Karnataka and the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA). The aim is to discover and support high-potential innovators to address Bengaluru's climate challenges.

On November 26-27, Shah participated and presented in a Regional Capacity Strengthening Workshop for the SAARC countries on the subject of "Building Climate and Disaster Resilient Roads and Bridges in Mountainous Regions" under the World Bank's Climate and Disaster Resilient Transportation Initiative, in collaboration with the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) and the Ministry of Road Transportation & Highways (MoRTH). Shah made presentations on two significant topics: Strengthening Governance for Building Infrastructure resilience and Climate Financing Resilient Road Infrastructure.

TIF Founder on Logistics Cost

In his monthly column in Business Standard, TIF Founder and Managing Trustee Vinayak Chatterjee focused on India recalibrating its logistics cost, and the fact that this area is no more the economic disadvantage as was hitherto perceived.

https://www.business-standard.com/opinion/columns/confidence-in-india-s-logistics-cost-the-story-of-economic-transition-125112001452_1.html



QUIZ: Test Your Infra Power

1. What is the amount invested in the new Research Development and Innovation (RDI) Scheme Fund to boost private sector-driven research and development?
2. Which cities has the Tamil Nadu Government demanded metros for?
3. What is the full form of GIFT City, designed as a global financial and IT hub in Gujarat?
4. Which industry is the government considering infra status for?
5. Which water structure did the late Dharmendra threaten to commit suicide from in the iconic 1975 film Sholay?

1. Rs 1 lakh crore
2. Coimbatore and Madurai
3. Gujarat International Finance Tec-City
4. The hotel industry, according to Minister for Culture, Gajendra Singh Shekhawat
5. Water tank



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